



Flat feet exercises

Arch and foot strength, step by step. A printable sheet from walkito.site.

How to use this sheet: start with the easier exercises and the lower dose. Mild discomfort is fine; sharp pain is not. If an exercise makes the pain worse the next morning, drop back a step. The doses are Walkito's starting doses, not a prescription. Full guide with videos and the studies: walkito.site/flat-feet-exercises



Towel scrunch

3 sets of 8, hold 5 seconds, each foot

Every session, while it is your level

Sit with a towel flat on the floor under your foot. Pull the towel in with your toes, and keep the heel down. The towel scrunch wakes up the small muscles under the arch.

Evidence: Early. Walkito's own addition. It was not part of the tested program in the studies on this page.



Big toe lift

3 sets of 8, hold 5 seconds, each foot

Every session, while it is your level

Sit with your feet flat. Lift only the big toe and hold. The other four toes stay flat on the floor. The big toe lift teaches the big toe to move on its own, which is the arch's first switch.

Evidence: Early. Walkito's own addition. It was not part of the tested program in the studies on this page.



Short foot, seated

3 sets of 8, hold 5 seconds, each foot

Every session, while it is your level

Sit with your foot flat on the floor. Pull the ball of the foot toward the heel so the arch lifts, and hold. Don't curl the toes. Curling them is the most common way to get this exercise wrong.

Evidence: Moderate. Part of the program that improved arch shape in a 2023 trial. On its own, short foot work has weaker results.



Short foot, standing

3 sets of 8, hold 5 seconds, both feet

Every session, while it is your level

Stand with your weight on both feet and do the same movement. The toes stay flat and long. Only the arch lifts. It is the same muscle as the seated version, now holding your weight.

Evidence: Moderate. Part of the program that improved arch shape in a 2023 trial. On its own, short foot work has weaker results.



Short foot, one leg

3 sets of 10, hold 5 seconds, each foot

Every session, while it is your level

Stand on one foot and lift the arch. Keep the big toe down. If it lifts, the arch is cheating. Working one foot at a time is where the weaker side shows.

Evidence: Moderate. Part of the program that improved arch shape in a 2023 trial. On its own, short foot work has weaker results.



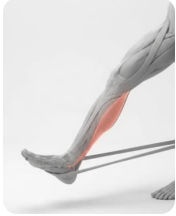
Toe spread

3 sets of 10, each foot

Strength days

Spread your toes as wide as they go, then hold. Toes that can spread share the load with the arch. Lifting them is not the point.

Evidence: Early. Walkito's own addition. It was not part of the tested program in the studies on this page.



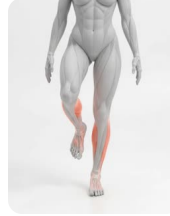
Band turn-in

3 sets of 12, each foot

Strength days

Sit with a resistance band around the foot and turn the foot in against it. Move the foot, not the leg. The knee stays still. Walkito adds the band turn-in only after six sessions of the standing short foot, so the arch's own muscles come first.

Evidence: Early. Walkito's own addition. It was not part of the tested program in the studies on this page.



Single-leg hold

3 holds of 20 seconds, each leg

Balance days

Stand on one foot and look at one fixed spot. Let the foot wobble. It's meant to, because that wobble is the foot doing the balancing.

Evidence: Early. Walkito's own addition. It was not part of the tested program in the studies on this page.



Hip abduction

3 sets of 10, each leg

Strength days

Stand with a resistance band and lift one leg out to the side against it. Push through the heel, not the toes. A hip that gives way lands the load on the arch.

Evidence: Moderate. Part of the program that improved arch shape in a 2023 trial.



Calf and soleus stretch

2 holds of 30 seconds for each stretch, each leg

Most sessions

Put your hands on a wall. Keep the back leg straight, the heel down and the hips forward, and feel the stretch in the calf. Then bend the back knee until you feel it lower, near the heel. That is the soleus, the deeper calf muscle.

Evidence: Moderate. Part of the program that improved arch shape in a 2023 trial. That trial measured arch shape, not pain.

Week log: tick what you did	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Towel scrunch							
Big toe lift							
Short foot, seated							
Short foot, standing							
Short foot, one leg							
Toe spread							
Morning pain (0 to 10)							

See a clinician first if

- the pain followed an injury or a fall
- you cannot put weight on the foot, or you are limping
- it comes with numbness, tingling, burning, swelling or warmth
- the heel is red, or you have a fever or feel unwell
- it wakes you at night
- it is sharp, or getting worse despite easing the load
- squeezing the sides of the heel hurts, or the pain builds during runs after you increased your mileage; both can be signs of a stress fracture
- you have diabetes, reduced feeling in your feet or poor circulation
- both heels hurt and other joints are swollen or stiff
- it has not improved after several weeks of exercise and a lighter load
- one arch has flattened suddenly as an adult
- the arch stays flat when the foot is off the ground

